# Access denied after approval: group membership and token refresh

Article KB0010011 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: Access request | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS devices (MacBook Pro/Air running macOS 14/15), Any device authenticating via Azure AD / Entra ID, SharePoint Online, Teams, OneDrive, file servers accessed over SMB, HR applications and line-of-business apps integrated with Entra ID

## Summary

After a manager approves an access request, users may still encounter "Access denied" when trying to open a shared drive, SharePoint site, HR system, or other resource. This typically occurs because the newly assigned security group has not yet been evaluated by the user's authentication token, or the token has not been refreshed. Signing out and back in (or waiting for the token refresh interval) usually resolves the problem.

## Symptoms

- "Access denied. You do not have permission to access this resource." when opening a mapped network drive or file share
- "HTTP 403 Forbidden: Access is denied." in SharePoint Online or Teams
- "You don't have access to this site. Contact your site administrator." when browsing a SharePoint site
- "Error 0x80070005: Access is denied." when trying to open a folder via File Explorer
- "Sign-in succeeded but the application returns an authorization error." in HR portals or custom apps

## Common causes

- New security group membership not yet evaluated in the user's access token
- Authentication token not refreshed after group change; Azure AD token lifetime (default 1?hour) still using the old token
- Conditional Access policies requiring MFA or compliant device not met due to a stale token
- Replication delay between on-premises AD and Azure AD for groups that are synced
- Approval missing or not recorded in the request workflow, so the group was never added

## Initial verification and symptoms

When a user reports access denial after an approval, first confirm the exact error message and the time the request was approved. Ask the user to note the resource they are trying to reach (e.g., \"Finance SharePoint\", \"HR system\", \"Project folder on Z:\\\") and whether they have already signed out and back in. This helps distinguish a token-refresh issue from a missing group assignment or a permission problem at the resource level.

## Self-help procedure for users

Follow these steps before contacting the Service Desk. They resolve the majority of "access denied after approval" cases by forcing a fresh token that includes the newly assigned group.

1. 1. Save any open work and close all applications that use the resource (e.g., File Explorer, browser, Teams).
2. 2. Click your profile picture in the top-right of the Windows taskbar or macOS menu bar and select **Sign out**.
3. 3. Wait at least 30?seconds, then sign back in using your usual credentials (you will be prompted for MFA via Microsoft Authenticator or SMS).
4. 4. After signing in, wait another minute and then try to access the resource again (open the SharePoint site, map the drive, or launch the HR app).
5. 5. If the error persists, repeat the sign-out/in once more and then contact the IT Service Desk, providing the exact error message and the time you performed the steps.

## Service-desk agent workflow

Agents should verify that the approval exists, confirm group membership, and advise the user to refresh their token. If the group is missing or not yet replicated, add the user and document the action.

1. 1. Open the ticket and retrieve the request ID, manager approval (email or workflow screenshot), and the target security group or SharePoint permission level requested.
2. 2. In Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) portal, search for the user's UPN and verify whether the requested security group appears under **Groups** -> **Member of**.

3. 3. If the group is present, instruct the user to perform the self-help sign-out/in steps above and ask them to retest access.
4. 4. If the group is missing, add the user to the group (or grant the specific SharePoint/NTFS permission) and note the change timestamp.
5. 5. Inform the user that token propagation can take up to 15?minutes; ask them to sign out and back in after waiting that period.
6. 6. Close the ticket only after the user confirms successful access.

## Verification and closure

Once the user reports that access is restored, capture confirmation details and close the ticket with appropriate resolution notes. This creates a clear audit trail for future reference.

1. 1. Ask the user to reply with a brief confirmation (e.g., \"I can now open the Finance SharePoint folder\" ) or provide a screenshot showing the resource accessible.
2. 2. Record in the ticket: the group added (if any), the time the user signed out/in, and the time access was verified.
3. 3. Set the ticket status to **Resolved** and apply the resolution category **Access granted after token refresh**.
4. 4. If the user still reports denial after completing the steps, escalate per the escalation guidance below.

## When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team when: the user has completed the self-help sign-out/in cycle at least twice without success, the requested group does not appear in Entra ID after verification, or replication latency between on-prem AD and Azure AD exceeds 2?hours. Include in the escalation: the ticket number, user UPN, requested group name, manager approval evidence (email or workflow ID), timestamps of the sign-out/in attempts, and any relevant error codes or Conditional Access policy reports from the sign-in logs.

*Keywords: access denied, group membership, token refresh, SharePoint access, file share permission, HR system access, Entra ID, Azure AD, MFA, sign out, conditional access, replication delay*